

From Paychecks to Peace of Mind: Can Money Truly Buy Happiness?

Wade Eckert

Bellevue University

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Dr. Audra Barrett

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The age-old question of whether money can buy happiness is often debated in overly simplistic terms. A few years ago, during a rough patch where I was juggling bills and skipping meals to make rent, the phrase “money doesn’t buy happiness” felt hollow and out of touch. That memory still lingers, shaping how I approach this topic. While it’s true that money can’t solve every problem, recent research and thoughtful analysis suggest that it *can* solve a lot—and that matters. My position is that money significantly contributes to happiness by alleviating stress and providing freedom, but it cannot fully secure the deeper, more enduring forms of fulfillment that define lasting happiness.

The updated research presented by Jennings (2024) in *Forbes* offers compelling evidence to reconsider the simplistic notion that happiness plateaus at a certain income. Jennings references Matthew Killingsworth's 2021 study, which demonstrates that happiness continues to rise significantly with income, even at levels considerably higher than the previously accepted threshold of \$75,000 per year. This new evidence is persuasive because it reflects modern economic realities where higher income provides not just material goods but valuable psychological benefits, such as reduced stress and increased autonomy. For instance, money allows individuals to purchase convenience, healthcare, better education, and security—things that directly correlate to enhanced emotional well-being and overall life satisfaction.

Yet, acknowledging that money buys comfort and immediate happiness doesn't necessarily imply that it also buys deeper forms of meaning or emotional fulfillment. Quoidbach’s (2023) article in the Esade Business Law School publication introduces a critical distinction that I found deeply insightful. According to Quoidbach, wealth can paradoxically

diminish the meaningful aspects of life. His research suggests that wealth may reduce empathy, community engagement, and the capacity to savor life's simple pleasures. These are critical components of deeper, long-term satisfaction. Money, in this sense, risks insulating individuals from the emotional richness of meaningful relationships and shared experiences, effectively trading meaningful human connections for comfort and independence.

Further supporting this perspective, Andy Millard (2020) writes on *Medium* about the phenomenon of the “happy poor and unhappy rich.” Millard points out that happiness is strongly associated with factors such as gratitude, humility, and deep social connections—qualities that do not necessarily correlate with wealth. While Millard does acknowledge the undeniable benefits of financial stability, he highlights the inherent limits of wealth in producing sustained happiness, emphasizing that genuine, enduring happiness often emerges from non-materialistic foundations such as gratitude and meaningful human interactions.

A particularly provocative perspective was offered in the article from the *Daily Mail* by Karbritz (2023), which bluntly argues for the pursuit of wealth as a direct route to happiness. Karbritz's straightforward approach of asserting that financial security ensures happiness and advising her daughter accordingly highlights a societal assumption many subconsciously hold. However, it also inadvertently underscores the pitfalls of equating wealth strictly with happiness without recognizing the complexity and nuances that Quoidbach and Millard point out.

Moreover, the *Wall Street Journal* article by Donnelly and Norton (2017) adds another layer of complexity by indicating that the source and perceived fairness of wealth affect happiness. They suggest that wealth gained through effort, fair compensation, or meaningful work is associated with higher happiness compared to wealth acquired effortlessly or through

inheritance. This indicates that how we obtain wealth—and not just how much wealth we possess—significantly influences our happiness levels, reinforcing the idea that not all forms of happiness are equally purchasable.

Reflecting upon these diverse viewpoints, it becomes clear that the money-happiness relationship is neither entirely straightforward nor universally applicable. Personally, I resonate deeply with Jennings' arguments about the tangible psychological relief that financial stability provides. Having experienced the stress of financial uncertainty, I know the immense emotional weight lifted when such anxieties are reduced. Yet, I also identify strongly with Quoidbach's point about the potential emotional and social isolation that wealth can unintentionally foster. It's crucial to actively maintain meaningful relationships and community involvement, even as financial security increases.

In synthesizing these insights, I conclude that money is indeed a significant component of happiness, primarily in reducing stress and providing freedom. Nevertheless, lasting happiness that is rich in meaning, connection, and fulfillment requires much more than financial resources alone. It necessitates deliberate cultivation of relationships, meaningful engagement with one's community, and mindful appreciation of simple daily experiences. Money may open the door, but it's not the destination. Recognizing this complexity allows us to pursue a more balanced and holistic approach to both our financial aspirations and our deeper human need for meaningful, enduring happiness.

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